OBS Recording Cheat Sheet

Screen + headset-mic recordings for YouTube. OBS Studio 32.2 on the Lenovo laptop (1920x1200 screen, Intel Iris Xe). Profile **YouTube**, scene collection **YouTube Recording**.

Hotkeys (work while OBS is minimized)

Action	Keys	Notes
Start / stop recording	`Alt+End`	Same key toggles. OBS tray icon turns red while recording.
Pause / resume	`Alt+Home`	Same key toggles. Pauses within the same file; no cut needed.
Mute / unmute mic	`Ctrl+Alt+F8`	Mutes the recorded mic only, not your call apps.

Caution: OBS does not block the key from the active app. In Chrome, Alt+Home also opens your home page, so pause from the terminal or another window. Plain Home/End are ShareX shortcuts. Mute keeps Ctrl+Alt+F8 (may need Fn held on this laptop).

Step 1 - Prepare the desktop (2 minutes)

1. Set Windows power mode to **Best performance** (Settings > System > Power). If you hear mains hum, try recording on battery: the charger is the suspected hum source.
2. Turn on **Do not disturb** (`Win+N` , bell icon). Display capture records everything on screen, including notification pop-ups.
3. Close anything you would not post publicly: email, password manager, chats, `.env` files, terminals showing tokens or keys. Assume every pixel is published.
4. Maximize Windows Terminal and Chrome. Increase text size for viewers: terminal `Ctrl+=` two or three times, Chrome zoom 125% (`Ctrl++`).
5. Plug in the Logitech headset **before** starting OBS so the mic is picked up.

Step 2 - Launch and check OBS

6. Open OBS. The title bar should read **Profile: YouTube - Scenes: YouTube Recording**. If not, pick them from the **Profile** and **Scene Collection** menus.
7. Confirm the preview shows your screen. The single scene is **Screen** with one locked source, **Display**.
8. Speak at normal volume and watch the **Mic** meter in the Audio Mixer: peaks should land in the yellow zone (about -20 to -9 dB) and never hit red. Only one meter appears; desktop audio is intentionally off.
9. Minimize OBS. It sits on the same screen, so leaving it open records the OBS window too.

Step 3 - Record

10. Press `Alt+End` . Wait two seconds before speaking so the opening is clean.
11. Work normally: switch between Terminal and Chrome with `Alt+Tab` . Whatever is on screen is recorded; no scene switching is needed.
12. Use `Alt+Home` to pause and resume for breaks, and `Ctrl+Alt+F8` to mute for a cough or an interruption.
13. Press `Alt+End` again to stop.

Step 4 - After recording

14. Find the file in `C:\Users\br8kw\Videos\OBS`, named by date and time, e.g. `2026-10-11 14-30-00.mp4`.
15. Play the first 15 seconds to confirm the mic is audible and text is readable.
16. Upload the .mp4 directly to YouTube Studio (or edit first). The file is Hybrid MP4, so it stays playable even if OBS or the laptop crashes mid-recording; no remuxing needed.
17. Still hear hum or a low level? From the myvinyl repo run `uv run tools/clean_audio.py "<file>.mp4"`. It writes <file>-clean.mp4 with hum removed and loudness evened out; the video is untouched.

First-time mic tuning (do once)

18. Record a 20-second test while talking normally, then play it back.
19. Too quiet or too loud: Audio Mixer > **Mic** three-dot menu > **Filters** > **Gain** (currently +16 dB). Adjust in 2-3 dB steps; the Windows mic level is already at 100%.
20. Hum still audible: open **Hum Removal (ReaEQ)** > Open Plug-in Interface and widen the notch bandwidth (0.06 to 0.15 oct), or add a Notch band at 60 Hz.
21. Hiss and keyboard noise are reduced by the **Noise Suppression** filter (RNNoise). Full details: docs/obs-recording-setup.md.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Fix
Preview is black	Right-click **Display** > Properties > Capture Method: **Windows 10 (1903 and up)**.
Mic meter does not move	Headset was plugged in after OBS started. Right-click Mic > Properties, reselect **Microphone (Logitech USB Headset)**, or restart OBS.
Recording stopped or paused by itself	Check the OBS tray icon. Press Alt+End to start a new file, or Alt+Home to resume if paused. Rebind in Settings > Hotkeys if it keeps happening.
Mute hotkey does nothing	Hold Fn, or enable Fn Lock (usually Fn+Esc).
"Encoding overloaded" warning	Close heavy apps; plug in power. If it persists, Settings > Output > Recording > Target Usage: **TU7 (speed)**.
Taskbar or OBS visible in video	Taskbar is cropped automatically. Minimize OBS before recording.
Notification appeared on screen	Cut it in editing. Next time enable Do not disturb (step 2).

Configured settings (reference)

Area	Setting
Video	Canvas and output 1920x1080 (16:9), 30 fps, Lanczos scaling, Rec. 709
Capture	Display Capture of the full 1920x1200 screen; bottom 72 px (taskbar) cropped; scaled to fit, which leaves thin black bars at the sides
Encoder	Intel QuickSync H.264, CQP 20, TU4 (balanced), High profile, 2 s keyframes, 3 B-frames
Audio	Mic only, 48 kHz, AAC 192 kbps on track 1. Filters in order: ReaEQ hum removal (2x high-pass 85 Hz, notches 180/300 Hz), Noise Suppression (RNNoise), Gain +16 dB, Compressor 4:1 at -18 dB, Limiter at -1 dB
Plugins	ReaPlugs 2.36 x64 (Cockos) in C:\Program Files\VSTPlugins\ReaPlugs
File	Hybrid MP4 in C:\Users\br8kw\Videos\OBS. Roughly 0.5-1.5 GB per hour for screen content
Rollback	Original config backed up to %APPDATA%\obs-studio-backup-2026-10-11. Or switch back to profile/collection **Untitled**.